

How Ambient AI Can Tackle the Documentation Burden in the Healthcare Industry



For a long period of time, healthcare organizations have been grappling with the growing challenge and frustration of being buried in clinical documentation - a burden healthcare providers wanted to get off their backs so they could focus on delivering high-value patient care. The adoption of electronic health records (EHRs) led to doctors, nurses, and other healthcare professionals investing significant amounts of time documenting patient encounters, updating patient records, reviewing charts, and completing compliance-related paperwork tasks. While electronic health records (EHRs) improved access to patient information and streamlined workflows, they added to the administrative workload as clinicians increasingly ended up spending too much time on data entry activities.

The Documentation Burden

This challenge became more acute as clinicians were devoting more time to interacting with computers than with patients. They were not only documenting during patient visits but also completing clinical notes after hours, navigating through growing documentation requirements, and increasingly complex digital workflows. The growing documentation burden substantially contributed to physician burnout, after-hours charting, lower productivity, and less time for focused patient care.

According to the American Medical Association (AMA) survey data, physicians spend an

average of 13 hours a week on indirect patient-care activities such as documentation, with 22.5% spending more than eight hours a week on EHR work outside normal hours. Another AMA survey revealed that 75% of physicians believe AI can improve work efficiency, while 54% see potential to help with stress and burnout.

Ambient AI in Action

This is where Ambient AI offers a new way forward. It acts as an intelligent, always-on digital assistant that listens to clinician-patient conversations, understands the clinical context, and automatically creates structured documentation in real time. Instead of relying on traditional note-taking, the technology operates quietly in the background, transforming conversations into clinical notes and mitigating administrative workload. This enables clinicians to avoid documentation burnout by investing more time listening, observing, and engaging with patients.

What is so compelling about Ambient AI is that its impact is already being seen in real-world clinical settings. A Stanford Health Care study involving physicians using Ambient AI scribes reported substantial reductions in task load and burnout, along with improvements in usability and efficiency. Physicians also reported better documentation quality and meaningful time savings.

Beyond Documentation

The significance of Ambient AI can be seen in its impact beyond reducing clinician burnout. A study across six U.S. healthcare systems found that clinician burnout dropped from 51.9% to 38.8% after just 30 days of using ambient AI. The clinicians also reported lower cognitive workload, less after-hours documentation, and more time to focus on patients during consultations.

These findings are reinforced by another survey of more than 1,400 clinicians across major academic health systems, which found that ambient technology was associated with improved well-being and lower documentation-related burnout.

It's important to understand that the real value of Ambient AI goes beyond efficiency metrics. Ambient AI has the potential to remove the documentation layer that has long distracted clinicians and restore the human connection at the heart of healthcare. This technology has become an invisible enabler of better care, helping clinicians be more present, attentive, and empathetic during patient interactions. After years of digitizing healthcare, Ambient AI represents the next step, helping clinicians spend less time on documentation and more time focused on patient care and healing.